Two columns of prose on shared baselines

Accessible documents carry a structure tree that names what each part of a page is: a heading, a paragraph, a list, a table or a figure. Assistive technology reads that tree rather than the order in which a producer happened to draw the text, so a page set in two columns reads one column after the other when its tree follows the reading order.

Some producers set such a page line by line, the first line of the left column and then the first line of the right one, on the same baseline. Rows of the two columns then line up as the rows of a table do, yet nothing on the page is tabular: no rule parts the rows, and every line runs on into the next one of its own column, never across the gutter.

A borderless table of short cells

Item	Quantity	Price
Paper	12	4.50
Toner	2	38.00
Staples	5	1.20
Folders	30	9.90